

Unveiling connections between organizational dimensions, employee performance and boundary-spanning behaviors: a study on perceived organizational support and perceived supervisory support

Unveiling
connections

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to examine the influence of perceived organizational support (POS) on boundary-spanning behaviors (BSBs) among frontline employees in the hospitality industry. It also considered perceived supervisory support (PSS) as a moderating factor within a conceptual model.

Design/methodology/approach – Data were gathered from 651 full-time hospitality employees across 12 hotels in China. The analysis of the data used confirmatory factor analysis and structural equation modeling.

Findings – The findings revealed that POS influences hospitality boundary spanners' BSBs, specifically external representation (ER), internal influence (II) and service delivery (SD). In addition, PSS moderates the relationship between POS and these frontline employees' behaviors.

Practical implications – This study offers practical strategies for hospitality professionals to enhance frontline employees' BSBs and foster supportive workplaces that drive employee excellence. These strategies encompass cultivating a supportive organizational culture, implementing supportive measures, fostering a sense of belonging among employees and ensuring supervisors' well-being and competence in supporting their teams during daily interactions. These actions effectively motivate customer-contact employees to excel in their performance.

Originality/value – Fostering a helpful attitude in frontline employees is crucial for service firms' success. Hospitality organizations must provide support to achieve this. Few studies have explored how organizational support contributes positively to the BSBs of customer-contact employees. This study goes beyond oversimplification and delves into the nuanced interplay between perceived support (POS and PSS) and hospitality frontline employees' BSBs, focusing on ER, II and SD. The

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1. Introduction

The hospitality industry, renowned for its susceptibility to uncertainties (Ghazi *et al.*, 2024) and the imperative to adapt to evolving customer demands (Ji *et al.*, 2022), has been profoundly impacted by the enduring COVID-19 pandemic. In today's landscape, customer expectations for service quality have escalated significantly, compelling hospitality organizations to consistently exceed existing service standards to remain competitive. Thus, survival in this context hinges on prioritizing customer satisfaction and positive performance outcomes, with frontline employees playing a pivotal role (Wang *et al.*, 2021b).

Frontline employees, often referred to as boundary spanners, serve as linchpins within organizations, bridging external customers with internal processes while delivering services according to organizational standards. Their behavior, conceptualized as boundary-spanning behaviors (BSBs) (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001), encompasses elements such as helpfulness, ensuring high-quality service, issue resolution and uncertainty management (Bettencourt and Brown, 1997). BSBs, a form of prosocial service behavior, not only provide insights into customer needs and expectations but also influence purchasing intentions and satisfaction (Liao and Chuang, 2004; Wang *et al.*, 2021b), thereby contributing to the organization's competitive advantage (Raza *et al.*, 2021).

The hospitality industry presents a notably demanding work environment (Kang *et al.*, 2020; Wang *et al.*, 2021a), including long working hours, excessive workloads and a lack of routine holidays (Xu *et al.*, 2022). Frontline employees must tolerate unattractive conditions, including rigid roles, monotonous tasks, limited decision-making, conflicting demands, inadequate development opportunities, low rewards, seasonal employment and job insecurity (Dorta-Afonso *et al.*, 2023; Wang *et al.*, 2021a). These conditions often discourage employees from going the extra mile or lead to disengagement from their primary responsibilities (Hamouche *et al.*, 2023; Xu *et al.*, 2022).

Given these challenges, it is imperative to reassess human resource (HR) management practices in the hospitality sector, viewing frontline employees as valuable assets rather than mere revenue drivers (Kloutsiniotis and Mihail, 2020; Raza *et al.*, 2021). Their skills and talents are indispensable for delivering effective customer service and upholding the organization's identity and reputation (Salameh *et al.*, 2022). Human capital resource management initiatives should equip employees to tackle new challenges (Kloutsiniotis and Mihail, 2020) and create dynamic, supportive workplaces conducive to employee excellence (Dorta-Afonso *et al.*, 2023). Therefore, it is essential to understand the mechanisms that encourage high-contact employees' BSBs in the hospitality industry.

Prior research underscores the significant influence of employees' perception of their work environment on their attitudes and behavior (Dorta-Afonso *et al.*, 2023; Kloutsiniotis and Mihail, 2020). Perceived organizational support (POS) plays a vital role in addressing negative issues in the hospitality industry, such as workplace aggression and turnover intentions, while enhancing customer satisfaction (Raza *et al.*, 2021; Xu *et al.*, 2022). Nevertheless, existing research in POS has often overlooked harnessing human strengths and optimizing organizational functioning (Luthans *et al.*, 2007). There is a pressing need to address Kang *et al.*'s (2020) call for more research, particularly in understanding how to

support the prosocial service behavior of customer-contact employees. This research is vital for its profound impact on high-quality service delivery and customer satisfaction, essential for the long-term success of service organizations (Bettencourt and Brown, 1997; Xu *et al.*, 2022). Eisenberger *et al.* (2020) emphasized the necessity for further research to elucidate how and when POS leads to enhanced customer service.

POS, as conceptualized in organizational support theory (OST), reflects employees' perceptions of the firm valuing their contributions (Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986). Supervisors, in this framework, often represent the organization, embodying its values for employees (Rhoades and Eisenberger, 2002). Numerous studies have explored the impact of perceived supervisor support (PSS) on various aspects of employee well-being, including emotional exhaustion, organizational commitment (OC), job satisfaction and turnover intentions (Kim *et al.*, 2010). While PSS is often treated as a form of social support provided by the organization (Garg and Dhar, 2014), it is essential to differentiate between POS and PSS as distinct concepts.

Currently, there is a paucity of research examining the joint impacts of POS and PSS on frontline employees' BSBs. In addition, empirical investigations into the moderating influence of PSS on the POS–BSB relationship and the moderated mediation effect of PSS in the POS–OC–BSB pathway are scarce. Addressing these gaps, this study aims to better understand how supervisors and organizational support influence the behaviors and mechanisms of hospitality boundary spanners. The study's objectives are as follows: assess whether POS activates specific dimensions of BSBs in the hospitality industry, uncover the mediating role of OC in the relationship between POS and BSBs among customer-contact employees in hospitality and explore the independent influence of PSS on the direct and indirect links between POS and the behaviors of hospitality boundary spanners. These findings not only enhance our theoretical understanding of BSBs but also offer actionable insights for hospitality organizations to enhance the performance of their customer-contact employees.

2. Literature review

This research is rooted in three theoretical frameworks: social exchange theory (SET), OST and leader–member exchange (LMX) theory. First, SET suggests that employees participate in a reciprocal relationship with the firm (Blau, 1964), contributing their commitment and efforts in return for incentives and rewards (Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986). Second, OST posits that individuals who perceive support from the organization are motivated to respond with positive behaviors, going beyond their prescribed duties (Aboramadan and Karatepe, 2021). Third, LMX theory emphasizes the significance of relationships between leaders and subordinates (Graen and Cashman, 1975), influencing subordinates' performance and attitudes (Kim and Koo, 2017). High-quality LMX relationships are characterized by subordinates with the supervisor's support, increased job autonomy and increased job evaluations (Garg and Dhar, 2014). Subsequently, individuals in such relationships are motivated to exceed the minimum requirements of their roles.

By integrating SET, OST and LMX, this research emphasizes the impact of perceived organizational and supervisory support on organizational outcomes, particularly individual performance and behaviors. In the setting of the hospitality industry, these theoretical perspectives are applied to elucidate the relationships between support dimensions and the BSBs of frontline employees.

2.1 Boundary-spanning behaviors

Boundary spanning involves interactions between an organization and its external environment, facilitated by individuals with personal connections who cross organizational

boundaries (Adams, 1976). These boundary spanners act as intermediaries, linking and coordinating activities, transferring information and collecting feedback externally and internally (Miles, 1976). Their role is essential for gaining knowledge and achieving various organizational goals, such as improved performance and customer satisfaction (Wang *et al.*, 2023b). In the service sector, frontline employees serve as crucial boundary spanners, responsible for delivering high-quality service, fostering communication and influencing customer preferences (Wang *et al.*, 2021b). Particularly in hospitality, customer-contact boundary spanners play a vital role in enhancing the customer–firm relationship, understanding customer preferences and introducing innovations (Kim and Koo, 2017).

Recognizing the instrumentality of frontline employees going beyond their formal roles in achieving service excellence, Bettencourt *et al.* (2001) introduced BSBs to explore the effects of truly exceptional service, which is demonstrated in three distinct aspects: external representation (ER), internal influence (II) and service delivery (SD) (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005). ER encompasses employees' helpful behaviors related to establishing relationships, vocalizing endorsements and advocating for a firm's products and services to external stakeholders (Bowen and Schneider, 1985). II takes place when employees initiate proactive communication with the firm to foster service excellence (Zeithaml *et al.*, 1988). SD regarding their positions' role performance, on the other hand, involves being responsive, courteous and flexible when serving customers (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988).

While previous research has examined the impact of BSBs on various outcomes, there has been limited attention given to the role of positive organizational factors in fostering BSBs. In the hospitality literature, the examination of factors promoting BSBs, especially the combined influence of POS and PSS, remains underdeveloped (Wang *et al.*, 2021a). Therefore, this study aims to bridge these gaps in understanding the organizational catalysts behind frontline employees' BSBs, especially the combined influence of POS and PSS on BSBs.

2.2 Perceived organizational support

POS, as conceptualized by Eisenberger *et al.* (1986), signifies the quality of organizational support and represents employees' perception of the organization's commitment to them (Burns, 2016). POS develops over multiple interactions, shaping employees' expectations based on past experiences of favorable or unfavorable treatment (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2020). It addresses employees' socioemotional needs and tangible rewards, motivating them to invest more effort in anticipation of future benefits (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2020).

POS significantly strengthens the bond between employees and the organization by presenting OC that is conceptualized as "the relative strength of an individual's identification with and involvement in a particular organization" (Mowday *et al.*, 1979; p. 226), driven by the norm of reciprocity (Raza *et al.*, 2021), wherein POS creates a sense of indebtedness and gratitude among employees, prompting them to feel obligated to reciprocate toward the organization. Research has demonstrated that when employees receive support from their organization, they feel obligated to reciprocate by striving for the organization's goals and displaying valuable commitment (Rhoades and Eisenberger, 2002). Several studies across various types of organizations have shown that POS is a robust predictor of OC (i.e. Wang *et al.*, 2022). In the hospitality industry, where boundary spanners face daily challenges, POS significantly influences OC (Garg and Dhar, 2014), leading to the following hypothesis:

H1. POS positively influences OC.

Reciprocity shapes employee–organization relationships, motivating employees to contribute more to achieve organizational objectives (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2020). POS encourages proactive and prosocial service behaviors among frontline employees (Chen *et al.*, 2017), benefiting both

customers and the organization (Li *et al.*, 2022; Wang *et al.*, 2021b). POS aligns employees' values with the organization's principles (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2020). It fosters a sense of belonging and organizational identification (Kloutsiniotis and Mihail, 2020), leading employees to become brand ambassadors (Wang *et al.*, 2021a) and actively promote the organization's image externally (Wang *et al.*, 2023a). These trends align with Xiong *et al.*'s (2013) perspective that hotel employees perceiving the increased level of POS feel psychologically attached to the hotel brand and should act as ambassadors for the hotel. In addition, POS positively influences employee behaviors toward customers and colleagues (Eisenberger and Stinglhamber, 2011), promoting service culture in the hospitality industry (Hu *et al.*, 2023). It empowers employees to take action, engage in constructive vocal behavior and contribute to organizational improvement (Kang *et al.*, 2020).

In the hospitality sector, POS provides emotional support to customer-contact employees, enabling them to deliver exceptional service and meet service goals (Garg and Dhar, 2014). It fosters organizational citizenship behavior, benefiting customers through improved service delivery (Xu *et al.*, 2022). Thus, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H2. POS positively influences ER (H2a)/II (H2b)/SD (H2c).

2.3 Organizational commitment and its role as a mediator

OC represents the attachment between employees and their organizations, encompassing belief in organizational goals and willingness to put forth effort, "reflecting a general affective response to the organization as a whole" (Mowday *et al.*, 1979; p. 226). Meyer and Allen (1991) expanded upon this concept by delineating three dimensions, including affective, continuance and normative commitment, among which affective commitment aligns with Mowday *et al.*'s (1979) description of OC and shows the clear-cut effects in motivating employees to achieve superior task performance (Garg and Dhar, 2014). Highly committed employees typically experience job satisfaction (Wang *et al.*, 2022) and align with the firm's goals (Li *et al.*, 2022; Ridwan *et al.*, 2020). In the hospitality sector, committed frontline employees become brand ambassadors, align with brand promises (Xiong *et al.*, 2013) and contribute positively to their workplace (Wang *et al.*, 2023a). They engage in activities that promote the organization's image and share positive word of mouth (Higginbottom, 2014).

Highly committed individuals feel obligated toward the organization, leading to organizational citizenship behavior like helping, showing initiative, displaying civic virtue and promoting the organization (Ridwan *et al.*, 2020). In the hotel industry, this sense of duty drives frontline employees to engage in proactive actions, seek better solutions, collaborate and share knowledge (Tan *et al.*, 2019; Wang *et al.*, 2021b).

OC also indicates enthusiasm for supporting the organization's goals, which is particularly crucial in the hospitality sector, where frontline employees represent the organization (Malhotra *et al.*, 2013). Empirical evidence in the service sector confirms that highly committed frontline employees consistently deliver high-quality service, invest discretionary effort to enhance customer satisfaction and contribute to loyalty and retention (Garg and Dhar, 2014; Wang *et al.*, 2023b). Therefore, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H3. OC positively influences ER (H3a)/II (H3b)/SD (H3c).

OC is influenced by factors such as POS, organizational climate and culture and socialization (Tan *et al.*, 2019). It serves as a precursor to positive outcomes, including organizational citizenship behavior (Tan *et al.*, 2019) and improved performance (Chen *et al.*, 2017). Notably,

some studies have identified the mediating role of organizational commitment in amplifying the influence of organizational factors, such as perceived support, on employees' favorable behaviors. For example, [Bettencourt and Brown \(2003\)](#) found that job satisfaction's influence on BSBs could be mediated by OC. [Rosnani \(2018\)](#) showed that emotional attachment to the organization mediates the relationship between servant leadership and extra-role behaviors. OC has been empirically examined as a mediator in the "benevolent leadership–organizational citizenship behavior" relationship in the hospitality industry ([Tan et al., 2019](#)). In addition, [Wang et al. \(2022\)](#) suggested that POS can lead to reciprocal BSBs among hospitality frontline employees through OC. This research assesses the mediating effect of OC on the linkage between POS and the three categories of BSBs, leading to the following hypotheses:

H4. OC mediates the association linking POS and ER (H4a)/II (H4b)/SD(H4c).

2.4 The moderating effect of perceived supervisory support

PSS refers to how supervisors support and care for their subordinates and provide support and encouragement for subordinates' work performance ([Eisenberger et al., 2010](#); [Kottke and Sharafinski, 1988](#)), distinct from POS ([Burns, 2016](#)). PSS influences employees' attitudes and behaviors and is related to, but not always a result of, POS ([Eisenberger et al., 2010](#)). Although subordinates can differentiate their relationships between their line manager and the organization ([Shi and Gordon, 2020](#)), POS and PSS can work concurrently and may exert different levels of influence on employees' outcomes ([Shanock and Eisenberger, 2006](#)). Supervisors play a vital role as intermediaries in organizations ([Shi and Gordon, 2020](#)). Because they represent the organization and provide daily support, their actions are seen as reflective of the organization's intentions ([Eisenberger and Stinglhamber, 2011](#)). Thus, PSS can influence POS, contributing to employees' sense of belonging and commitment ([Shi and Gordon, 2020](#)).

In addition, LMX suggests that various types of relationships form between leaders and staff in work-related interactions ([Graen and Cashman, 1975](#); [Graen and Scandura, 1987](#)). Previous studies have shown that a weak supervisor–subordinate relationship is less likely to foster employees' organizational commitment than a strong connection between leaders and members ([Garg and Dhar, 2014](#)). Exploitative supervision, which reflects a low level of PSS, is negatively associated with the organizational commitment of service employees in the hospitality industry ([Sun et al., 2023](#)). Hence, the following hypothesis:

H5. PSS moderates the association of POS with OC, such that the positive association is stronger for employees high in PSS.

In addition to the stronger relationship between PSS and OC for boundary spanners ([Edmondson and Boyer, 2013](#)), it is particularly evident that high-quality LMX relationships enhance autonomy, leading boundary spanners to willingly engage in behaviors that benefit their leaders, colleagues and customers ([Wang et al., 2021b](#)). It also fosters a deeper sense of ambassadorship for the hotel ([Wang et al., 2021a](#)) and cultivates strong personal connections between supervisors and subordinates, enabling boundary spanners to effectively perform their information-processing roles through formal and informal communication channels ([Wu et al., 2024](#); [Wang et al., 2023b](#)). Moreover, the increased PSS means empowerment to use workplace resources to tailor service experiences to meet individual customer requirements ([Akgunduz et al., 2023](#)). Consequently, PSS amplifies the perception of POS among hospitality frontline employees and encourages them to go the extra mile in

delivering exceptional service (Xu *et al.*, 2022). The positive relationship mentioned above serves as a promoter of hotel frontline employees' BSBs. Conversely, low-quality supervisor–subordinate relationships can lead to negative attitudes and behaviors (Al-Hawari *et al.*, 2020; Garg and Dhar, 2014). Therefore, our study proposes the following hypotheses:

- H6.* PSS moderates the association of POS with ER (*H6a*)/II (*H6b*)/SD (*H6c*), such that the positive association is stronger for employees high in PSS.

Recent research highlights the prominence of supervisors in the hospitality industry (Ji *et al.*, 2022). Frontline employees excel when well supported by supervisors (Akgunduz *et al.*, 2023), fostering commitment and loyalty (Kim and Koo, 2017), both significant precursors to organizational citizenship behavior (e.g. Tan *et al.*, 2019). A high level of PSS propels dedicated boundary-spanning employees to go above and beyond in supporting, fulfilling and even transcending their supervisor's goals. For instance, they may actively participate in promoting the company's image, seek innovative solutions and collaborations and strive for exceptional service delivery (Wang *et al.*, 2023b).

Conversely, low-quality LMX relationships are characterized by limited levels of support, trust and understanding, which do not inspire members or subordinates to exceed minimum requirements. In the context of hotel businesses, weak supervisor–subordinate relationships may lead to disconnection, affecting job attitudes and performance (Hamouche *et al.*, 2023). Thus, high PSS boosts OC, encouraging proactive behaviors beyond expectations (Tan *et al.*, 2019), while weak LMX relationships lead to reduced performance (Sun *et al.*, 2023) and diminished service quality (Garg and Dhar, 2014). Hence, the following hypotheses:

- H7.* PSS moderates the association of OC with ER (*H7a*)/II (*H7b*)/SD (*H7c*), such that the positive association is stronger for employees high in PSS.

The quality of LMX significantly influences the organizational attitudes and behaviors of employees. Close leader–team relationships in hotels make subordinates feel that they are valued within the group. When combined with a high level of PSS, these relationships constitute a vital form of organizational support (Kurtessis *et al.*, 2017), enhancing group loyalty (Akgunduz *et al.*, 2023). This, in turn, amplifies employees' OC, resulting in elevated job performance, innovative service behaviors (Kim and Koo, 2017) and customer-oriented extra-role behaviors (Akgunduz *et al.*, 2023). Thus, a moderated mediation effect exists, with PSS amplifying the impact of POS on employees' BSBs via OC, leading to the following hypotheses:

- H8.* PSS moderates the indirect association of POS on ER (*H8a*)/II (*H8b*)/SD (*H8c*) via OC, such that the indirect association is stronger for employees high in PSS.

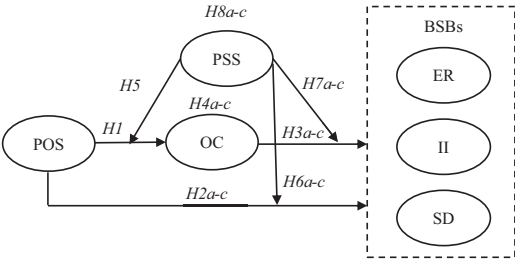
Based on the preceding arguments, we have constructed a conceptual model for the research (Figure 1).

3. Methodology

3.1 Data collection

This study assessed the model using full-time hospitality employees from 12 hotels in China, including five five-star and seven four-star hotels. The participants were frontline employees, including receptionists, food and beverage staff, concierge personnel, bellpersons and porters. Data collection occurred in August 2022, following meetings with hotel chief executive officers or HR directors to explain the study's objectives and potential

Figure 1.
Conceptual
framework



Source: Authors' own creation

Table 1.
Demographic
analysis

Variable (N = 651)	Characteristics	No.	Frequency (%)
Gender	Male	345	53.0
	Female	306	47.0
Age	18–24	394	60.5
	25–34	107	16.4
	35–44	128	19.7
	45–54	20	3.1
	Above 55	2	0.3
Education	Less than high school	71	10.9
	High school graduate	77	11.8
	College or university graduate	493	75.7
	Postgraduate and above	10	1.5
Years of work experience	Less than 1 year	322	49.5
	1–3 years	138	21.2
	More than 3 years	191	29.3
Job positions	Reception	84	12.9
	Concierge	65	10.0
	Bellman	17	2.6
	Waiter/waitress	236	36.3
	Banquet attendant	84	12.9
	Bartender	37	5.7
	Fitness center attendant	33	5.1
	Housekeeper	63	9.7
	Duty/shift manager	32	4.9

Source: Authors' own creation

condensed five-item version of [Kottke and Sharafinski's \(1988\)](#) scale. For measuring the three dimensions of BSBs, [Bettencourt and Brown \(2003\)](#) developed a nine-item scale and [Bettencourt et al. \(2005\)](#) extended it into a 13-item scale, including ER (four items), II (four items) and SD (five items), which were adopted by this study (see [Table 2](#)). All constructs used seven-point Likert-type scales, ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree. Participants also provided job-related and demographic information. To maintain

Constructs	Items	SRW	<i>t</i> -value	SMC	CR	AVE
POS	My organization values my contributions to its well-being	0.759	NA	0.576	0.896	0.590
	– strongly considers my goals and values	0.765	15.697	0.585		
	– is willing to help me when I need a special favor	0.650	12.015	0.423		
	– shows a lot of concern for me	0.783	14.521	0.613		
	– cares about my opinions	0.853	15.165	0.728		
OC	– takes pride in my accomplishments at work	0.786	14.574	0.618	0.904	0.702
	I find that my values and my firm's values are similar	0.819	NA	0.671		
	My firm really inspires the best in me	0.837	25.568	0.701		
	I really care about the fate of my firm	0.841	25.097	0.707		
	For me, my firm is a good organization for which to work	0.854	25.828	0.729		
PSS	My supervisor cares about my well-being	0.860	NA	0.740	0.939	0.754
	If I did the best job possible, my supervisor would be sure to notice	0.811	26.089	0.658		
	My supervisor cares about my general satisfaction at work	0.899	32.045	0.808		
	My supervisor shows a lot of concern for me	0.868	29.785	0.753		
	My supervisor cares about my opinions	0.900	31.658	0.810		
ER	I always tell outsiders this is a great place to work	0.852	NA	0.726	0.917	0.735
	– generate favorable goodwill for our company	0.907	31.105	0.823		
	– say good things about our company to others	0.785	24.239	0.616		
	– promote our company's products and services	0.880	29.441	0.774		
	I always make constructive suggestions for service improvement	0.767	NA	0.588		
II	– contribute many ideas for our product	0.783	20.110	0.613	0.853	0.592
	promotions and communications					
	– share creative solutions to customer problems with other team members	0.753	18.436	0.567		
	– encourage coworkers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement	0.774	18.994	0.599		
	I always follow up customer service guidelines with extreme care	0.754	NA	0.569		
SD	– show responsiveness to my customers	0.830	23.081	0.689	0.890	0.619
	– show my courteous and respectful to customers	0.784	21.107	0.615		
	– keep promises to my customers	0.772	21.263	0.596		
	– show personal attentiveness to my customers	0.793	19.758	0.629		

Source: Authors' own creation

Table 2.
Results of
confirmatory factor
analysis

participants' focus during the survey, attention check questions were incorporated into the questionnaire.

3.3 Data analysis

Descriptive analysis provided an initial overview of the constructs. Using AMOS 23.0, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) confirmed structural relationships among the model's factors and constructs. The measurement scales' reliability and validity were assessed, focusing on internal consistency and construct validity. Structural equation modeling (SEM) evaluated the hypothesized paths, with model fit assessed using widely accepted fit indices, following [Anderson and Gerbing's \(1988\)](#) guidelines.

4. Results

4.1 Measurement model

The measurement model yielded the following results: $\chi^2 = 720.29$, $df = 210$, $\chi^2/df = 3.43$, goodness-of-fit index = 0.910, comparative fix index (CFI) = 0.950, normalized fix index = 0.932, incremental fix index = 0.951, Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) = 0.940 and RMSEA = 0.061. These results meet the standard acceptance criteria recommended by [Hu and Bentler \(1999\)](#). Specifically, the RMSEA is below 0.08, and both CFI and TLI exceed 0.90, indicating a strong fit.

A CFA was conducted on a 28-item set encompassing POS, OC, PSS, ER, II and SD ([Table 2](#)). The results indicate that all standardized regression weights for these constructs exceeded 0.5 and were highly significant ($p < 0.001$). For the loading of each factor ([Hair et al., 2010](#)), the t -values exceeded the threshold of 1.96. Moreover, the average variance extracted (AVE) among these constructs, at its lowest, was 0.590, which surpasses the 0.50 threshold, confirming the convergent validity ([Fornell and Larcker, 1981](#)). For the factors, composite reliability (CR) scores ranged from 0.853 to 0.939. Specifically, POS exhibited a CR of 0.896, OC 0.904, PSS 0.939, ER 0.917, II 0.853 and SD 0.890. These CR values all exceeded the recommended benchmark of 0.70, affirming strong internal consistency for the measurement scales, in line with the criteria established by [Bagozzi and Yi \(1988\)](#). To confirm discriminant validity of the scales, we compared the AVE scores with the squares of correlation coefficients ([Chin, 1998](#)). [Table 3](#) shows that the AVE scores, positioned on the diagonal of the matrix, surpassed the squares of the off-diagonal, paired correlation coefficients, thus confirming discriminant validity.

4.2 Hypotheses testing

In the structural model examined via SEM in AMOS 23.0, most hypothesized relationships, except $H6c$, were consistent with our predictions. POS had a strong positive influence on

Table 3.
Discriminant validity
assessment

Constructs	POS	OC	PSS	ER	II	SD
POS	0.590					
OC	0.554	0.702				
PSS	0.464	0.501	0.754			
ER	0.397	0.569	0.391	0.735		
II	0.256	0.343	0.278	0.445	0.592	
SD	0.176	0.165	0.387	0.231	0.188	0.619

Source: Authors' own creation

frontline employees' attitudes and behaviors toward the hospitality organization (Table 4) ($\beta_{\text{POS} \rightarrow \text{OC}} = 0.767, t = 13.475$; $\beta_{\text{POS} \rightarrow \text{ER}} = 0.12, t = 2.099$; $\beta_{\text{POS} \rightarrow \text{II}} = 0.247, t = 3.251$; $\beta_{\text{POS} \rightarrow \text{SD}} = 0.547, t = 13.695$), supporting *H1*, *H2a*, *H2b* and *H2c*. OC also positively predicted hospitality frontline employees' BSBs ($\beta_{\text{OC} \rightarrow \text{ER}} = 0.751, t = 11.911$; $\beta_{\text{OC} \rightarrow \text{II}} = 0.517, t = 6.623$; $\beta_{\text{OC} \rightarrow \text{SD}} = 0.113, t = 2.543$), confirming *H3a*, *H3b* and *H3c*. Furthermore, the mediating role of OC between POS and ER, II and SD was confirmed using bootstrapping at a 95% confidence interval (Table 5), accepting *H4a*, *H4b* and *H4c*.

This study also investigated moderation and moderated mediation hypotheses using AMOS. *H5* and *H6a–c* posited that PSS moderates the positive association between POS and OC, as well as BSBs, making the associations stronger when PSS is high. The results, as demonstrated in Table 6, show that PSS significantly moderates the link between POS and OC ($\beta_{\text{PSS*POS} \rightarrow \text{OC}} = 0.094, t = 2.141$), supporting *H5*. In addition, PSS moderates the positive relationships between POS and ER and II, respectively ($\beta_{\text{PSS*POS} \rightarrow \text{ER}} = 0.308, t = 4.590$; $\beta_{\text{PSS*POS} \rightarrow \text{II}} = 0.248, t = 2.966$), while its moderating effect on the POS and SD relationship is insignificant ($\beta_{\text{PSS*POS} \rightarrow \text{SD}} = 0.035, t = 0.634$). Thus, *H6a* and *H6b* were supported while *H6c* was not. Furthermore, PSS moderates the positive association between OC, ER, II and SD ($\beta_{\text{PSS*OC} \rightarrow \text{ER}} = 0.336, t = 4.181$; $\beta_{\text{PSS*OC} \rightarrow \text{II}} = 0.225, t = 1.964$; $\beta_{\text{PSS*OC} \rightarrow \text{SD}} = 0.160, t = 2.079$), supporting *H7a*, *H7b* and *H7c*.

AMOS was also used to assess the moderated mediation effect of POS on hospitality frontline employees' ER, II and SD through OC at higher (+1 standard deviation) and lower levels (–1 standard deviation) of PSS. It indicates that PSS enhanced the indirect impact of POS on hospitality frontline employees' ER, II and SD via OC (Table 7). These indirect effects were significant when PSS was high, with bootstrapped bias-corrected 95% confidence intervals not including zero for ER (0.029, 0.260, $p < 0.05$), II (0.032, 0.457, $p < 0.05$) and SD (0.019, 0.138, $p < 0.05$) via OC, contingent on mean +1 standard deviation PSS. These findings confirmed *H8a*, *H8b* and *H8c*.

Table 4.
Direct effects of POS
on OC and BSBs

Hypotheses	Path	SRW	Unstd RW	SE	t-Value	P	Result
<i>H1</i>	POS → OC	0.767	0.97	0.072	13.475	***	Supported
<i>H2a</i>	POS → ER	0.12	0.165	0.079	2.099	0.036	Supported
<i>H2b</i>	POS → II	0.247	0.273	0.084	3.251	0.001	Supported
<i>H2c</i>	POS → SD	0.547	0.42	0.018	13.695	***	Supported
<i>H3a</i>	OC → ER	0.751	0.817	0.069	11.911	***	Supported
<i>H3b</i>	OC → II	0.517	0.452	0.068	6.623	***	Supported
<i>H3c</i>	OC → SD	0.113	0.069	0.027	2.543	0.011	Supported

Source: Authors' own creation

Table 5.
Mediation effect of
OC between POS and
BSBs

Hypotheses	Path	Bias-corrected 95% CI			P	Result
		Boot std estimates	Lower	Upper		
<i>H4a</i>	POS → OC → ER	0.576	0.448	0.824	0.001	Supported
<i>H4b</i>	POS → OC → II	0.397	0.216	0.674	0.002	Supported
<i>H4c</i>	POS → OC → SD	0.087	0.01	0.173	0.027	Supported

Source: Authors' own creation

Table 6.
Moderation and
moderated mediation
analysis of PSS

Hypotheses	Path	SRW	RW	SE	<i>t</i> -value	<i>P</i>	Result
<i>H5</i>	POS → OC	0.448	0.735	0.094	7.834	***	Supported
	PSS → OC	0.464	0.425	0.028	15.400	***	
	PSS*POS → OC	0.094	0.109	0.051	2.141	0.032	
<i>H6a</i>	POS → ER	0.396	0.701	0.057	12.341	***	Supported
	PSS → ER	0.169	0.167	0.071	2.340	0.019	
	PSS*POS → ER	0.308	0.344	0.075	4.590	***	
<i>H6b</i>	POS → II	0.307	0.440	0.149	2.957	0.003	Supported
	PSS → II	0.151	0.121	0.069	1.760	0.078	
	PSS*POS → II	0.248	0.250	0.084	2.966	0.003	
<i>H6c</i>	POS → SD	0.300	0.333	0.037	9.028	***	Not supported
	PSS → SD	0.094	0.058	0.049	1.192	0.233	
	PSS*POS → SD	0.035	0.028	0.044	0.634	0.526	
<i>H7a</i>	OC → ER	0.650	0.701	0.057	12.341	***	Supported
	PSS → ER	0.169	0.167	0.071	2.340	0.019	
	PSS*OC → ER	0.336	0.256	0.061	4.181	***	
<i>H7b</i>	OC → II	0.624	0.545	0.090	6.052	***	Supported
	PSS → II	0.151	0.121	0.069	1.760	0.078	
	PSS*OC → II	0.225	0.139	0.071	1.964	0.049	
<i>H7c</i>	OC → SD	0.492	0.333	0.037	9.028	***	Supported
	PSS → SD	0.094	0.058	0.049	1.192	0.233	
	PSS*OC → SD	0.160	0.076	0.037	2.079	0.038	

Source: Authors' own creation

Table 7.
Analysis of
moderation on
indirect mediation

Hypotheses	Path		Estimates	Bias-corrected 95% CI			Percentile 95% CI			Result
				Lower	Upper	<i>P</i>	Lower	Upper	<i>P</i>	
<i>H8a</i>	POS → OC → ER	PSS High	0.064	0.029	0.260	0.017	0.027	0.235	0.022	Supported
		PSS Mean	0.038	0.003	0.073	0.046	0.002	0.069	0.271	
		PSS Low	−0.024	−0.126	0.049	0.821	−0.267	0.044	0.796	
<i>H8b</i>	POS → OC → II	PSS High	0.093	0.032	0.457	0.017	0.029	0.401	0.022	Supported
		PSS Mean	0.033	−0.286	0.073	0.357	−0.300	0.062	0.519	
		PSS Low	−0.092	−0.103	0.066	0.603	−0.116	0.054	0.621	
<i>H8c</i>	POS → OC → SD	PSS High	0.021	0.019	0.138	0.037	0.016	0.116	0.042	Supported
		PSS Mean	−0.021	−0.313	0.078	0.314	−0.289	0.073	0.355	
		PSS Low	−0.106	−0.157	0.023	0.074	−0.161	0.016	0.068	

Source: Authors' own creation

5. Discussion and conclusions

5.1 Conclusions

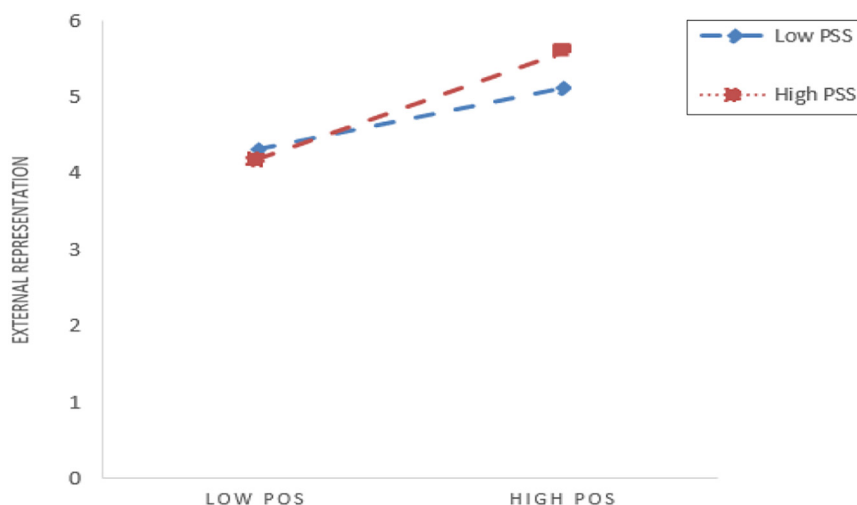
From a social exchange perspective, this study addresses a gap by investigating the role of organizational support as a predictor, psychological factors as mediators and supervisory support as a moderator in understanding BSBs. Most hypotheses are supported, highlighting the importance of POS in predicting the BSBs of hospitality frontline employees. Specifically, employees perceiving higher organizational support are more likely to demonstrate greater OC, leading to increased BSBs. The study also reveals that high PSS can enhance the direct relationship between POS and hospitality frontline employees' ER and II. Moreover, it strengthens the indirect relationship between POS and BSBs mediated

by OC. These findings contribute to SET, OST and BSB literature by elucidating the intricate interplay among POS, PSS and OC as drivers of BSBs.

First, the study revealed that POS has direct and indirect positive effects on frontline employees' ER, II and SD. These findings strongly support Eisenberger *et al.*'s (1986) OST, which suggests that when employees perceive favorable treatment from their organization, it nurtures a positive association between employees and the organization (Tan *et al.*, 2019). This commitment motivates employees to exceed their job roles in pursuit of organizational goals (Kurtessis *et al.*, 2017). Consequently, POS acts as a catalyst, driving employees to not only fulfill their roles but also actively contribute to the organization's objectives, as seen in previous research (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2020).

Second, POS significantly predicts the OC of customer-contact employees, aligning with the principles of SET proposed by Blau (1964). SET suggests that interactions involve mutual interdependence, where individuals exchange their commitment for tangible incentives and socioemotional benefits. POS effectively satisfies employees' needs for approval, affiliation and emotional support, thereby fostering their identification with the organization and the development of OC, as evidenced in prior research (Rhoades and Eisenberger, 2002). In addition, OC was revealed to partially mediate the linkage between organizational support and BSBs, consistent with SET's principles. According to SET, employees who receive support at work tend to reciprocate with positive attitudes such as OC. OC is a robust indicator of superior employee performance, associated with behaviors such as organizational citizenship behavior and extra-role behavior (Rosnani, 2018).

Finally, PSS, examined for its moderating effects, emerges as a crucial moderator that enhances BSBs in customer-contact employees. PSS amplifies the positive associations between POS and ER and II, as illustrated in Figures 2 and 3. In addition, this study reveals that PSS enhances the indirect positive impact of POS on all three categories of BSBs (ER, II and SD) through the conduit of OC. This finding aligns with the principles of LMX theory, which posits that supervisors form unique relationships with subordinates during work-related exchanges (e.g. Graen and Scandura, 1987). Employees who perceive high



Source: Authors' own creation

Figure 2.
Interactive effect of
POS and PSS on ER

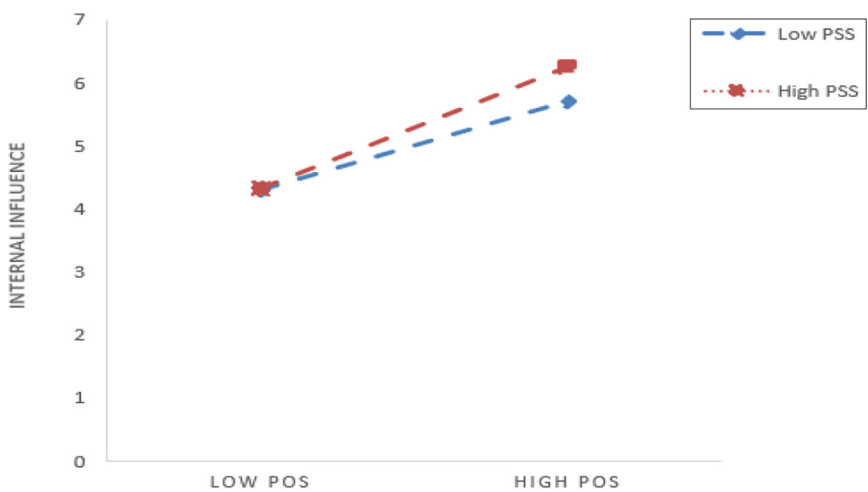


Figure 3.
Interactive effect of
POS and PSS on II

Source: Authors' own creation

supervisory support are more inclined to respond positively to favorable treatment from their supervisors, leading to increased POS, greater commitment to the workplace and higher organizational involvement. This perspective emerges from the perception that employees regard their supervisors as representatives of the organization, thereby reflecting the intentions and policies of the organization itself (e.g. Eisenberger and Stinglhamber, 2011). However, the moderating effect of PSS on the linkage between POS and SD-related BSBs was deemed nonsignificant. This indicates that PSS does not significantly influence the relationship between POS and BSBs related to service delivery. This finding aligns with Garg and Dhar (2014), suggesting that the supervisor–subordinate relationship may not immediately impact the quality of service delivery.

5.2 Theoretical implications

This study represents an advancement in our understanding of OST (Aboramadan and Karatepe, 2021; Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986), LMX theory (Garg and Dhar, 2014; Graen and Cashman, 1975; Graen and Scandura, 1987; Kim and Koo, 2017) and the broader literature on BSBs in the hospitality industry, drawing from the contributions of various scholars (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2005; Wang *et al.*, 2021a; Wang *et al.*, 2023b). First, instead of oversimplifying the impact of either POS or PSS on predicting employees' behaviors (Garg and Dhar, 2014; Xu *et al.*, 2022), this study provides a more nuanced understanding by examining the concurrent dyadic influence of perceived support. This approach provides a richer and more comprehensive perspective on the dynamics of support within the organizational context (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2010; Shi and Gordon, 2020).

Second, the study's findings affirm the significance of perceived support as a positive influencer of the behaviors exhibited by customer-contact employees (Garg and Dhar, 2014; Kang *et al.*, 2020; Shi and Gordon, 2020). In particular, it sheds light on how this perceived support plays a crucial role in shaping the dimensions of ER, II and SD. This contribution enhances the existing body of knowledge in the field of BSBs within the hospitality setting

(Wang *et al.*, 2021a; Wang *et al.*, 2022). It not only broadens our understanding but also provides a more intricate and nuanced perspective on this subject matter.

Third, OC was tested as a significant mediator between POS and BSBs. This finding aligns with prior research, demonstrating that commitment emerges in response to POS (Garg and Dhar, 2014; Wang *et al.*, 2022). Moreover, it underscores the importance of frontline employees who are psychologically in alignment with the firm and demonstrate identification with its objectives, as they tend to perform both in-role and extra-role boundary-spanning tasks more effectively (Fatima *et al.*, 2023; Kang *et al.*, 2020; Wang *et al.*, 2022; Wang *et al.*, 2023b).

Finally, the proposed framework addresses the call to explore how POS and PSS influence employees' behavioral intentions simultaneously (Eisenberger *et al.*, 2010). Particularly, the moderated mediation model of this study reveals that POS serves as the antecedent to BSBs, specifically ER, II and SD. It also delves into the moderating impact of PSS on the relationship between POS and these frontline employees' behaviors. Therefore, this study not only enhances our comprehension of the mechanisms through which perceived support impacts employees' behaviors (Kang *et al.*, 2020; Tan *et al.*, 2019; Wang *et al.*, 2022) but also provides a deeper insight into how support dynamics enhance customer-contact BSBs (Li *et al.*, 2022; Wang *et al.*, 2022). Overall, as a pioneering effort in this area, this study makes valuable contributions to the literature by emphasizing the distinct, independent influences of POS and PSS in promoting the BSBs of frontline employees in the hospitality sector.

5.3 Practical implications

This research provides practical insights into the hospitality industry in the following aspects. First, the findings reveal the importance of perceived supports in terms of their desirable effects on fostering customer-contact employees' BSBs in the hotel industry, thus highlighting the need for a supportive organizational culture. Frontline employees, who bridge the gap between the organization and its external environment, require a multifaceted BSB promotion system integrated with training, empowerment, rewards and thoughtful job design. Specifically, these measures include besides regular training on job descriptions, procedures, standards and skills, workshops about service improvement and innovation should be arranged regularly, using real cases from the hotels in recognition of individuals and teams; addressing issues of overwork and irregular shifts by adopting service robots for unpleasant, repetitive and nonessential interpersonal tasks, person-job fit is considered as crucial; and establishing a channel, such as an online platform for sharing both work- and nonwork-related problems, would establish an instant understanding of frontline employees' support requirements and a quick follow-up procedure. Such measures would create a supportive environment conducive to BSBs among frontline employees.

Second, this study emphasizes the indirect relationship between POS and BSBs mediated by OC. To encourage these behaviors among high-contact employees, hospitality enterprises should prioritize cultivating supportive strategies and implementing management interventions, including providing job security, ensuring fairness, involving employees in decision-making and offering professional development opportunities to create an attractive work environment; enhancing frontline employees' commitment to the organization by advocating organizational aims, missions and visions to help brand internalization, thus leading to BSBs; and nurturing frontline employees' career development planning alongside the organization's own development to promote proactive behaviors among frontline employees. Consequently, long-term relationships between employees and the organization would flourish, fostering BSBs such as advocating for the

organization, assisting colleagues, aligning with goals and consistently delivering exceptional service.

Third, this study highlights the crucial role of PSS as an independent factor in enhancing BSBs among frontline employees. A higher level of PSS strengthens the direct positive link between POS and BSBs, specifically ER and II. It also reinforces the indirect connection between POS and BSBs via OC. To leverage these insights, hospitality organizations should: expand their focus to cultivating supervisory support. They should ensure that supervisors, who often set the tone for employee experiences, pay attention to their own words and deeds in their daily contact with their subordinates and are equipped to pass on supportive treatment from the organization to their subordinates; train supervisors to understand subordinates' needs and respond to requests for support; and encourage supervisors to foster workplace meaningfulness and team cooperation by building positive formal and informal relationships with frontline employees and provide periodic training to supervisors with a focus on nurturing service orientation. In addition, hotels can organize training interventions focused on cultivating supportive attributes among supervisors (Fatima *et al.*, 2023). HR departments may also treat one's supportive nature as a requirement of supervisory recruitment and promotion.

6. Limitations and future studies

This study possesses limitations suggesting potential directions for future research. First, while examining POS and PSS effects on frontline employees' BSBs, it is important to acknowledge the multifaceted nature of POS and PSS. Future research could explore specific elements within POS/PSS for a nuanced understanding of their impact. Second, considering hospitality frontline employees' position at the organizational boundary, exploring additional support sources such as coworker support or customer involvement could offer further insights into BSB drivers. Thirdly, demographic variables, including age, gender, education and work experience, were not investigated, which could be considered as control variables to uncover personal differences influencing BSBs. Fourth, this study focused on Chinese four/five-star hotels with a collectivistic culture, limiting generalizability. Future studies should consider diverse cultural backgrounds and hospitality business types. Finally, data collected from full-time employees using self-reported questionnaires may raise common method bias concerns. Future research could validate findings with observed workplace behaviors to ensure robustness.

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